

Word family: **timely / timelier / timeliest / timeliness / untimely**

Base word: timely

Part of speech: mainly **adjective**

Related forms:

* **timely** (adj.) — 及時的；適時的；正合時宜的

* **timeliness** (n.) — 及時性；合時宜

* **untimely** (adj.) — 不合時宜的；過早的；不適時的

* **untimely death** — 英年早逝；過早死亡

* **in a timely manner** — 及時地；在合適時間內

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **timely apology**

* **timely response**

* **timely action**

* **timely reminder**

* **timely intervention**

* **timely information**

* **timely decision**

* **in a timely manner**

* **timeliness of**

* **untimely delay**

* **untimely death**

Meaning in this passage

> ...when it is honest, **timely**, and specific, it can really mend the situation.

Here, **timely** means:

happening soon enough and at an appropriate moment to be useful or effective — 及時的；在合適時機發生的

The apology mattered partly because Kevin did not wait too long. He apologized the next day, while the incident was still fresh and before resentment had time to grow.

中文翻譯：

只要道歉是真誠、**及時**而且具體的，就真的可以修補局面。

So here:

****timely = 在最需要、最有幫助的時候出現，而不是拖得太遲****

1. ****timely (及時的 ; 適時的) — 及時的****

This is the exact sense used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> A ****timely apology**** can really mend the situation.

一個****及時的道歉****真的可以修補局面。

Practice 2

> Her ****timely response**** prevented the problem from getting worse.

她****及時的回應****阻止問題惡化。

Practice 3

> We received a ****timely warning****.

我們收到了一個****及時的警告****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****timely = 在合適而且不太遲的時間發生，因此能產生幫助或效果的****

2. ****timely apology — 及時的道歉****

Very relevant to your passage.

Practice 1

> His ****timely apology**** helped clear the air.

他****及時的道歉****有助化解不快。

Practice 2

> A ****timely apology**** can prevent resentment from building.

****及時道歉****可以避免不滿逐漸累積。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****timely apology = 在事情發生後不久、仍能有效修補關係時作出的道歉****

3. ****timely response — 及時回應****

Practice 1

> Thank you for your ****timely response****.

多謝你的****及時回覆****。

Practice 2

> A ****timely response**** is important during a crisis.

危機期間，****及時回應****很重要。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****timely response = 在情況仍需要處理時迅速而適當地作出的回應****

4. ****timely action — 及時行動****

Practice 1

> ****Timely action**** prevented further damage.

****及時行動****防止了進一步損失。

Practice 2

> The problem could have been solved with more ****timely action****.

如果更早採取****及時行動****，問題可能已經解決。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****timely action = 在最佳或必要時間採取的行動****

5. ****timely intervention — 及時介入****

Practice 1

> Her **timely intervention** stopped the argument from escalating.

她**及時介入**，阻止爭吵升級。

Practice 2

> Early and **timely intervention** can make a big difference.

及早而**適時的介入**可以帶來很大分別。

MCQ-ready definition:

timely intervention = 在情況惡化前的合適時機介入

6. **timely reminder** — 及時提醒

Practice 1

> The message was a **timely reminder** of the deadline.

那個訊息是對截止日期的一個**及時提醒**。

Practice 2

> Her comment was a **timely reminder** to stay calm.

她的說話**及時提醒**我們要保持冷靜。

MCQ-ready definition:

timely reminder = 在正需要提醒的時候出現的提醒

7. **timely information** — 及時資訊

Practice 1

> Managers need accurate and **timely information**.

經理需要準確而**及時的資訊**。

Practice 2

> The team did not receive **timely information** about the change.

團隊沒有及時收到有關變動的**最新資訊**。

MCQ-ready definition:

timely information = 在仍然有用、能幫助作決定的時間內提供的資訊

8. **timely decision** — 適時決定

Practice 1

> A **timely decision** saved the project.

一個**及時的決定**挽救了項目。

Practice 2

> Leaders sometimes need to make **timely decisions** with limited information.

領導者有時需要在資料有限時作出**適時決定**。

MCQ-ready definition:

timely decision = 在最合適、仍能影響結果的時間作出的決定

9. **in a timely manner** — 及時地；在合理時間內

A very common formal expression.

Practice 1

> Please respond **in a timely manner**.

請**及時回覆**。

Practice 2

> The issue was handled **in a timely manner**.

這個問題得到**及時處理**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****in a timely manner = 在合適、合理而不拖延的時間內****

10. ****timeliness (及時性) — 及時性 ; 合時宜****

Practice 1

> The ****timeliness**** of the apology mattered.

那次道歉的****及時性****很重要。

Practice 2

> Accuracy and ****timeliness**** are both important.

準確性和****及時性****都很重要。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****timeliness = 某件事是否在合適、足夠早的時間發生的特質****

11. ****the timeliness of something — 某事的及時程度****

Practice 1

> We appreciated the ****timeliness of her response****.

我們很欣賞她回應得****很及時****。

Practice 2

> The ****timeliness of the warning**** helped prevent harm.

警告的****及時性****有助避免傷害。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****timeliness of X = X 發生得是否足夠及時和合適****

12. ****untimely (不合時宜的 ; 不適時的) — 不合時宜的****

The main opposite.

Practice 1

> His joke was **untimely**.

他的笑話來得**很不合時宜**。

Practice 2

> The interruption was **untimely**.

那次打斷來得**不是時候**。

MCQ-ready definition:

untimely = 發生在不合適的時間，因此令人覺得不恰當或帶來問題

13. **untimely death** — 過早死亡；英年早逝

A lexicalized strong sense.

Practice 1

> The book discusses the artist's **untimely death**.

這本書談到那位藝術家的**英年早逝**。

Practice 2

> His **untimely death** shocked the community.

他的**過早離世**震驚了社區。

MCQ-ready definition:

untimely death = 在被認為太早、尚未到自然預期時間便發生的死亡

14. **untimely interruption** — 不合時宜的打斷

Practice 1

> An **untimely interruption** broke his concentration.

一次**不合時宜的打斷**破壞了他的專注。

Practice 2

> The announcement came at an **untimely moment**.

公告在一個**很不是時候的時刻**出現。

MCQ-ready definition:

untimely X = X 發生在不合適的時間點

Important distinction 1: **timely vs on time**

This is the biggest distinction.

on time

at the scheduled time; not late.

timely

at a useful or appropriate time.

> The train arrived on time.

> 火車準時到達。

> His apology was timely.

> 他的道歉來得及時。

An apology does not usually have a fixed timetable, so **timely** is the better word.

Important distinction 2: **timely vs punctual**

punctual

a person/event consistently arrives at the scheduled time.

timely

something happens at an effective moment.

> punctual employee

> 準時的員工

> timely intervention

> 及時介入

Do not say:

> *punctual apology* ❌

Important distinction 3: **timely vs early**

early

before the expected/normal time.

timely

at the right time—not necessarily early.

Something can be too early and therefore not timely.

So:

timely ≠ simply early

Important distinction 4: **timely vs immediate**

immediate

happens at once, with almost no delay.

timely

happens soon enough to be useful.

Kevin's apology the next day may be **timely** without being literally immediate.

Important distinction 5: **timely vs prompt**

prompt

quick, with little delay.

****timely****

appropriate in timing and useful.

> prompt reply

> 迅速回覆

> timely advice

> 在關鍵時刻給出的建議

They overlap, but ****timely**** emphasizes suitability of timing more.

Important distinction 6: ****timely vs appropriate****

****appropriate****

suitable generally.

****timely****

suitable specifically because of ****when**** it happens.

> appropriate words

合適的說話

> timely words

在正需要時說出的話

Important distinction 7: ****timely vs relevant****

****relevant****

connected to the topic.

****timely****

well-timed.

A comment may be relevant but come too late to be timely.

Important distinction 8: **timely apology vs sincere apology**

Your passage gives both.

sincere

the apology is genuine.

timely

the apology comes at the right time.

A sincere apology can still lose some effect if it comes far too late.

Important distinction 9: **timely vs specific**

Again, your passage deliberately separates them.

timely

when the apology happens.

specific

how clearly it identifies the wrongdoing.

So the three adjectives cover different dimensions:

* **honest** → truthfulness

* **timely** → timing

* **specific** → precision/content

Important distinction 10: **timeliness vs speed**

speed

how fast something happens.

timeliness

whether it happens at the right time.

Fast is not always timely; a rushed decision can be too early.

Important distinction 11: **untimely** does not simply mean **late**

late

after the expected time.

untimely

inappropriate because of timing, or prematurely early in special phrases.

For example:

> untimely death

means **too early**, not late.

This is a very important semantic trap.

Family-extension note

Timely has a stable semantic core:

happening at a time when it is especially useful, appropriate, or effective

That gives us:

1. **useful timing**

- * timely apology
- * timely response
- * timely action

2. **formal timing expression**

- * in a timely manner

3. **noun quality**

* timeliness

4. **opposite**

* untimely = badly timed

* untimely death = prematurely early death

Unlike many words in your database, **timely** is not massively polysemous. The important learning value is in distinguishing **right timing** from mere **punctuality or speed**.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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timely	及時的；適時的	right/useful time	
timely apology	及時的道歉	repair before too late	
timely response	及時回應	useful response timing	
timely action	及時行動	act before too late	
timely intervention	及時介入	intervene at right moment	
timely reminder	及時提醒	useful reminder	
timely information	及時資訊	available while useful	
timely decision	適時決定	decide at right point	
in a timely manner	及時地	without undue delay	
timeliness	及時性	quality of good timing	
untimely	不合時宜的	badly timed	
untimely interruption	不合時宜的打斷	wrong moment	
untimely death	過早死亡；英年早逝	premature death	

For your original sentence

> Of course, an apology does not erase everything overnight, but when it is honest, **timely**, and specific, it can really mend the situation.

Here:

timely = 道歉沒有拖太久，而是在仍然可以有效修補關係、化解不快的時候作出

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 當然，道歉並不能一夜之間抹走所有事情，但只要它是真誠、**及時**而且具體的，就真的可以修補局面。

The key contrast is:

> **on time** = 準時

> **prompt** = 很快

> **timely** = 來得正是時候

For Kevin's apology, **timely** is the best word because the issue is not a timetable—it is whether he apologized **soon enough** for the apology to still have real repairing power.